

Technical Students' Attitudes Toward Academic Cheating and the Misuse of AI in Academic Activities

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Abstract – This study investigates student cheating behaviors, the role of artificial intelligence in facilitating academic dishonesty, and the underlying motivations behind such conduct among students at a technical university. It also explores students' perceptions of what constitutes “excusable” versus “inexcusable” reasons for cheating and evaluates strategies aimed at preventing dishonest practices. The findings reveal that cheating is a widespread phenomenon, often supported by digital tools such as mobile phones, the internet, and AI-based applications. Students frequently attributed their behavior to external pressures, including demanding course structures and limited time, suggesting that cheating is often perceived as a coping mechanism. While students recognized the existence of institutional deterrents, such as plagiarism detection systems, a considerable number were still willing to take risks. According to students, improving academic support, ensuring fairness in assessment, and enforcing rules consistently could effectively promote academic integrity and reduce dishonest behaviour.

Keywords – Student academic cheating, usage patterns in cheating, motivation to cheat, detection and prevention, AI ethics.

1. Introduction

Academic integrity is fundamental to the credibility of educational institutions, especially at technical universities, where students are expected to develop critical thinking, problem-solving skills, and an in-depth understanding of their field. However, the rise of technological advancements has brought about new challenges in maintaining academic honesty as noted by [1]. Student academic cheating, traditionally involving plagiarism, exam dishonesty, and unauthorized collaboration, has increasingly incorporated more sophisticated methods, such as the use of artificial intelligence. Misuse of AI can compromise the learning process but also undermines the ethical foundation of education, as reported by [2]. This shift raises significant ethical concerns, particularly regarding the integrity of students' learning processes and the potential long-term consequences for their professional development.

At technical universities, where the emphasis is placed on technical expertise, students are often under immense pressure to excel academically. This pressure, combined with the availability of AI tools, such as essay generators, code-writing assistants, and even AI-driven exam aids, can tempt some students to bypass the intellectual effort required for true learning. While AI has the potential to enhance education, its misuse for cheating undermines the very purpose of technical education. The most prevalent forms of AI-assisted cheating include using AI to complete assignments, write essays, solve complex problems, and even take exams. AI-powered platforms, such as chatbots and writing generators, can produce coherent and well-structured academic content, making it easy for students to submit work that is not their own. Additionally, AI algorithms designed to optimize research can help students find and present information without fully engaging with the material or understanding its underlying concepts as noted by [3]. This leads to a detrimental cycle where students may graduate with degrees but lack the essential knowledge and skills required in their chosen fields.

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According to [4], the ethical dilemma becomes even more pronounced when AI-generated solutions obscure the distinction between students' own capabilities and those of automated systems, ultimately compromising their ability to apply what they have learned in real-world settings.

From an ethical standpoint, the use of AI for academic cheating raises questions about fairness, accountability, and the long-term value of a technical degree. It challenges the ethical principles of honesty and respect for the learning process, as students who rely on AI-generated work may be perceived as dishonest or lacking in essential skills. Moreover, these practices may distort assessments of academic achievement, disadvantaging students who put in genuine effort. Additionally, the misuse of AI in academic settings risks eroding trust between students, faculty, and the broader academic community as noted by [5].

As AI tools become more integrated into education, universities must address the ethical implications of their use. According to [6], this involves not only setting clear guidelines for acceptable AI use but also fostering a culture of integrity and personal responsibility among students. Balancing the benefits of AI as a legitimate educational tool with its potential for misuse is key to preserving the ethical standards of academic environments, particularly in technical universities, where innovation and integrity must go hand in hand [7].

2. Literature Review

The literature on academic cheating at technical universities highlights the complex and evolving nature of the problem, with AI playing a central role in transforming cheating behaviors as noted by [8], and by [9]. Students in technical programs are increasingly leveraging AI tools to complete assignments and exams, which undermines the integrity of their education and creates disparities in academic achievement. Universities must respond by investing in AI detection tools, promoting academic integrity, and providing ethical education on AI use. By addressing these issues, institutions can help preserve the credibility of technical education and ensure that graduates possess the necessary skills to succeed in their fields. The present literature review examines recent studies, focusing on student cheating behaviors at technical universities, with an emphasis on usage patterns in cheating, emerging trends, ethical concerns and implication, detection and prevention.

2.1. Usage Patterns in Cheating

Cheating at technical universities, which focus heavily on fields such as engineering, computer science, and applied sciences, is not a new phenomenon. However, recent literature highlights an increase in the complexity of cheating methods. In a study by [10], it was observed that while traditional cheating methods—such as copying during exams and submitting plagiarized work—remain in some cases prevalent, students are increasingly using digital tools to facilitate dishonest behavior.

In [11], a comprehensive analysis of student cheating across multiple disciplines found that technical students, especially those in computer science and engineering programs, were more likely to use software tools to aid in cheating. This is partly due to their proficiency with technology, which allows them to manipulate systems designed to ensure academic integrity. The authors also note that the anonymity and convenience provided by digital tools make it easier for students to cheat without facing immediate detection.

In [12], study on AI-assisted cheating in higher education, it was noted that AI-based tools are frequently used by students in technical programs to generate solutions to assignments, write essays, and solve coding problems. The study points out that the line between legitimate academic assistance and unethical use of AI is becoming increasingly blurred, complicating efforts to define and detect cheating.

The use of AI-driven systems in technical universities is especially concerning because of the specialized nature of the academic tasks involved. In a report by [7], it was revealed that students in engineering programs used AI to generate complex engineering solutions and even bypass required lab work. This trend has prompted discussions on whether AI's role in academic settings should be restricted to avoid further erosion of academic integrity.

In a survey of 500 engineering students conducted by 40 % of respondents admitted to using unauthorized sources during exams or assignments, while 25 % reported that they believed others engaged in similar behaviors. Peer behavior also significantly influences students' attitudes toward cheating, with many students indicating that if they perceive cheating as widespread, they are more likely to engage in it themselves. This finding aligns with the classical social learning theory, which suggests that students may adopt behaviors seen in their peers [13].

2.2. Ethical Concerns and Implications

Academic integrity is a critical concern in higher education, particularly among technical students who are exposed to increasingly sophisticated tools and methods. Cheating, whether in traditional settings or online courses, undermines the value of education and can lead to serious consequences. With the integration of artificial intelligence (AI) into education, new opportunities and risks have emerged. Students may misuse AI to cheat or manipulate academic assessments, raising concerns among educators and policymakers alike.

The ethical concerns surrounding AI-assisted cheating are profound. According to [2], the use of AI for cheating not only compromises the learning process but also undermines the ethical foundation of education. In this sense, students may graduate with degrees that do not reflect their true abilities, which can have long-term consequences for their professional careers and the reputation of the institutions they graduate from. In addition to these concerns, issues related to data privacy and the potential marginalization of human educators have also been raised [20].

In addition to individual impacts, AI-driven cheating poses a threat to academic fairness. As noted by [4], the proliferation of AI in academic cheating means that students who do not resort to such shortcuts are at a disadvantage, especially in highly competitive environments like technical universities. This creates an uneven playing field and raises questions about the equity of academic evaluations. Furthermore, institutions face a growing challenge in detecting AI-generated content, as these tools become increasingly sophisticated, making traditional plagiarism detection software less effective.

Moreover, in [8], the authors emphasize the importance of creating educational programs that highlight the ethical use of AI in academic settings. By educating students on the risks and ethical implications of AI misuse, universities can mitigate the temptation to engage in dishonest behaviors. They suggest that promoting academic honesty should be a priority at technical universities, particularly as AI continues to evolve and become more embedded in students' daily lives.

The use of AI in academic writing has generated significant interest in AI-related plagiarism. According to [14] and [19], AI-giarism is an emergent form of academic dishonesty involving AI and plagiarism within the higher education context. She introduces a novel instrument to explore conceptualisation of AI-giarism, offering a significant tool for educators and policy-makers.

AI-giarism refers to the unethical practice of using artificial intelligence technologies, particularly generative language models, to generate content that is plagiarised either from original human-authored work or directly from AI-generated content, without appropriate acknowledgement of the original sources or AI's contribution.

2.3. Detection and Prevention

Several recent studies have examined strategies to detect and prevent cheating in technical universities, particularly in the age of AI. The potential of advanced AI tools to detect AI-assisted cheating is explored by [15]. They analyze patterns in student submissions that might indicate the use of generative models. They suggest that institutions should invest in AI-driven detection systems, as these tools are better equipped to identify the subtle markers left by AI-generated content. Additionally, they advocate for increased emphasis on developing students' ethical decision-making and fostering a culture of academic integrity.

A study by [16] found that technical students perceive cheating as more common in online courses compared to face-to-face settings. This is partly due to the reduced supervision in online courses and the availability of technology, which makes it easier for students to cheat. For example, students may use search engines, external devices, or unauthorized sources during assessments. In technical education, where skills like coding, engineering design, and scientific analysis are critical, cheating can also manifest in the form of plagiarizing code or using pre-written solutions without understanding the material. Additionally, motivation for cheating among technical students often ties to the pressure to succeed in competitive fields. Many students report feeling overwhelmed by the demands of their coursework and resort to dishonest practices as a shortcut to achieving high grades or meeting deadlines.

The misuse of AI is not limited to technical fields. In a study by [17], the authors found that many students in STEM programs admitted to using AI tools to generate answers to math problems or to automate tasks in coding assignments. Although these tools may enhance learning when used responsibly, they also present a significant challenge for educators who must find ways to detect and prevent cheating facilitated by AI.

On the other hand, AI also has the potential to improve academic integrity. AI-driven plagiarism detection software, such as Turnitin, can identify copied content across vast databases of academic works.

Additionally, AI-based proctoring systems have been implemented in online courses to monitor students during exams and detect suspicious behaviors, such as the use of unauthorized devices. While these systems have raised privacy concerns, they also provide a means to combat cheating in the digital age.

There is also a growing call for educators to incorporate AI literacy into their curricula. As noted by [12] and [18] and [21], teaching students about the potential risks of AI misuse and the ethical considerations surrounding AI technologies is essential in preparing them for both academic and professional environments. Institutions must create policies and resources that foster responsible AI use, ensuring that students are aware of the consequences of academic dishonesty and how AI can be used to enhance learning, rather than circumvent it.

The misuse of AI and academic cheating among technical students remains a significant issue in higher education. While technical students may perceive academic cheating as more prevalent in online courses, AI technologies introduce both challenges and opportunities for improving academic integrity. Educators must adapt to this changing landscape by implementing ethical guidelines, fostering AI literacy, and using AI-driven tools to detect and prevent academic dishonesty. Addressing these issues will help create a more equitable and effective learning environment for all students.

3. Problem Statement - Research Objectives

This research aimed to explore the prevalence, patterns, and underlying motives of academic cheating among technical students, with a particular focus on the influence of recent technological advancements, such as Artificial Intelligence (AI). It examined the frequency of cheating behaviors, the role of AI in facilitating such actions, and the factors that would motivate students to cheat. Additionally, the research investigated what students perceived as "excusable" reasons for cheating and evaluate potential strategies for detecting and preventing academic dishonesty. Through a questionnaire-based survey, this study sought to provide insights into how universities and educators can address and reduce cheating in academic settings, fostering a more honest and effective learning environment.

3.1. Research Questions

In light of the identified problem, this study was guided by a set of research questions designed to comprehensively investigate the complex issue of academic dishonesty among students in the digital age.

1. What is the prevalence of student academic cheating?
2. What are the prevailing usage patterns in academic cheating?
3. What is the role of AI in cheating?
4. What are dominant motives to cheat?
5. What are „excusable” and “inexcusable” motives?
6. Are there any possibilities for detecting student cheating?
7. How can universities and teachers prevent students from cheating?

3.2. Research Methodology

A quantitative approach was employed in the study to gather and evaluate data on the perspectives of technical university students on academic cheating. Before conducting the study, research ethical approval was obtained from the university's administration.

The 12 item-survey measured student attitudes and perceptions about cheating. Students were asked to rate their beliefs for a variety of cheating scenarios and to discuss how often they engaged in any of the behaviours themselves. In addition, demographic data such as study program, year of study, age, gender were collected.

3.3. Questionnaire Design and Administration

The present study employed a quantitative survey design to comprehensively define the current state of cheating among students across two technical faculties. A structured questionnaire was used to collect data, enabling both quantitative and qualitative analysis. Before designing the questionnaire, the aim and scope of the study were defined by revisiting relevant literature. Then, interviews were held with several students to get more insight into their views on the issue. During the design, a draft of the questionnaire was created, including general instructions, personal information, and the questionnaire items.

In the introductory part, a short paragraph informed potential respondents about the researchers and the goal of the survey. Personal information enabled to define the characteristics of sample in terms of gender, grade level, study program, age, and faculty. The body of the questionnaire included 18 questions asking students to describe their opinions. Next, opinions were gathered from two experts from each faculty, for a total of four, who had experience and expertise in ethical student behavior in academic activities. Three items were deleted, and the remaining 15 were modified based on the experts' feedback. A pilot implementation phase was then conducted with students to check for intelligibility, and some items were remodified based on their feedback.

Final form consisted of 11 items including both close-ended and open-ended questions: closed questions generally streamline the survey process, making it more efficient for both respondents and researchers while ensuring consistent, easy-to-compare data. Open-ended questions allow respondents to provide detailed, nuanced responses in their own words, rather than selecting from predefined answer choices.

3.4. Participants

The research was administered via an online questionnaire. Participants were recruited through an online platform, they were given an informed consent form before completing the survey, and participation was voluntary and anonymous. Participants were allowed to skip questions they were not comfortable answering.

4. Research Results

This section presents the key findings of the present research on student academic dishonesty in the context of generative AI use. The results are based on data collected through a questionnaire survey conducted among university students. The present study focuses on students' actual experiences with cheating, their use of AI tools for academic purposes, and their attitudes towards the ethical boundaries of such behavior.

4.1. Sample Characteristics

The participants' gender, faculty, study program, and age were collected in the demographic section of the questionnaire, as shown in Table 1.

Table 1. Sample characteristics

Sample characteristics (n=360)		n	%
Gender	Male	205	56.94
	Female	153	42.77
	Non-Defined	2	0.55
Faculty	Electrical Engineering	163	45.28
	Information Technology	197	54.72
Study Programme	Bachelor	246	68.33
	Master	114	31.66
Age	18-20	34	9.44
	21-23	280	77.77
	24-26	14	3.88
	More than 26	32	8.88

Male students outnumbered female students in the sample (69.3 %). Respondents were students from the faculties of Electrical Engineering and Information Technology of TU from Czechia. Two-thirds of them were Bachelor's students, 90% fell into the 18-26 age category.

4.2. Prevalence of Cheating

The data in Table 2 shows a relatively high incidence of cheating within this group of respondents, with about 43.9 % admitting to frequent cheating (always or often) and another 42.8 % admitting to occasional cheating (sometimes or rarely). This suggests that 86.7 % of students engage in some level of cheating, either frequently or occasionally.

Table 2. Prevalence of cheating

Prevalence of cheating	n=360	%
Always	86	23.9
Often	72	20.0
Sometimes	80	22.2
Rarely	74	20.6
Never	48	13.3

The percentage of students who report never cheating (13.3 %) is relatively low compared to the other categories, further suggesting that cheating is seen as somewhat common or widespread within this group.

4.3. Prevailing Types of Student Cheating

Table 3 presents data on the different types of student cheating and their frequency, which is indicated by the number of occurrences for each type. The top methods of cheating are closely tied to digital resources (e.g., mobile phones, internet access, AI tools), suggesting that technology plays a major role in enabling academic dishonesty. Methods like cribbing from fellow students and using old tests point to a culture of collaboration where students exchange resources to gain unfair advantages. It is clear that cheating practices are evolving alongside advancements in technology, with newer methods like AI help and internet-based solutions becoming more prevalent.

Table 3. Prevailing types of student cheating

Types of misuse	Number of occurrences
Misuse of older tests	128
Illegal Use of crib in mobile phone	126
Unethical AI help	124
Deliberate cribbing from fellow student	102
Plagiarism	96
Getting answers from the internet during the test	94
Distant online test filled with the help of other people	90
Photograph of test questions	88
Use of "classical" (pre-prepared) cribs	83
Fabricating data or sources	75
Submitting the same work for multiple assignments	71

4.4. Perception of Other Students' Cheating

Most students perceive academic cheating as a frequent occurrence in their environment. This indicates a widespread concern about academic integrity and may suggest a culture of low trust or perceived academic pressure among the student body.

Table 4. Perception of other students' cheating

Perception of other students' cheating	n=360	%
Always	130	36.1
Often	102	28.3
Sometimes	87	24.2
Rarely	19	5.3
Never	22	6.1

A significant majority (88.6 %) of students perceive that cheating occurs "always", "often" or "sometimes" in their environment (Table 4). This suggests that most students feel dishonest behavior is very common, there's a strong sense that cheating is a frequent issue in the student community. Only a small percentage of students (around 11.4 %) perceive that dishonest behavior happens rarely or never, indicating that most students do not believe cheating is rare in their environment. The overwhelming perception of frequent cheating might suggest a general lack of trust or a high tolerance for dishonesty in the community. It could indicate that students might either feel compelled to cheat due to academic pressures, or they may believe that cheating is a widely accepted or overlooked behavior. This indicates a highly negative perception of academic integrity within the group surveyed.

The data highlights that most students perceive a high frequency of cheating in their environment. This might point to concerns around academic integrity, possible issues with the academic culture, or a lack of sufficient deterrents to cheating. Further investigation into the causes and solutions for this perception could be valuable for improving academic ethics and reducing dishonest behavior.

4.5. Prevailing Types of AI Misuse

In recent years, the integration of Artificial Intelligence (AI) into everyday life has sparked a technological revolution across various sectors, including education. However, with these advancements comes a growing concern: The potential for AI to be used in unethical ways, particularly by students seeking to cheat. The fifth item of the questionnaire was an open-ended question asking students to suggest possible types of misuse in academic activities. Table 5 suggests types of cheating based on AI misuse as described by students.

Table 5. Types of AI misuse

Type of misuse form	Description
Generating essays or papers	Misuse of language model to generate texts or research papers. Students input assignment prompts, and the AI provides a fully formed response that students submit as their own work
Paraphrasing or rewriting	Use of AI powered paraphrasing tools to take an existing text and rephrase it in a way that avoids direct plagiarism
Answering exam questions	In an online exam setting, students may use AI to generate answers to questions. AI tools can quickly provide responses, allowing students to bypass their own understanding or critical thinking
Solving problem sets	In subjects like mathematics, science, or engineering, students may use AI driven problem-solving tools to generate solutions to complex problems
Research and summarization	AI can quickly generate summaries of research articles, books and other materials. Students rely solely on these summaries instead of engaging with the original materials
Creating fake citations or references	AI can generate a list of citations or fabricate non existing references. Student work appears well-researched and credible.
Completing written assignments	Outsourcing student work entirely to AI
Providing homework solutions	AI helps students with homework assignments across various subjects, including quizzes and practice tests

The misuse of AI undermines academic integrity by enabling students to bypass learning, critical thinking, and the process of developing their own knowledge and skills. This behavior is becoming a growing concern for educators and institutions, especially as AI technologies continue to evolve and become more widely accessible. Students use AI to generate entire essays or research papers based on assignment prompts, submitting them as their own work without original input, AI-powered tools are used to rephrase existing texts to avoid direct plagiarism, making it appear as if the work is original.

During online exams, students rely on AI to generate answers quickly, bypassing the need for their own understanding or critical thinking. In fields like mathematics, science or engineering, students use AI-driven tools to solve complex problems instead of doing the work themselves, AI generates summaries of research articles or books, allowing students to rely on these summaries rather than engaging with the full original materials, it can fabricate citations or create non-existent references, giving the false impression of a well-researched and credible paper. Some students outsource their entire written assignments to AI, completely bypassing personal involvement in the work. AI is used to assist with homework across various subjects, including quizzes and practice tests, offering ready-made solutions.

4.6. Motivation for Cheating

The motivation behind student cheating is a complex issue, often stemming from a mix of external pressures, internal struggles, and practical considerations. This part of the study analyzes the survey data to categorize and understand the dominant factors that drive students to engage in academic dishonesty, providing key insights into the root causes of this behavior. The students' motivations for cheating are shown in Table 6.

Table 6. Motivation for cheating

Motive to cheat	n=360	%
The course was not interesting	229	63.6
The course was difficult	197	54.7
Low self-esteem	183	50.8
Knew I would not get caught	164	45.6
AI is ready to help	113	31.4
Material was not explained clearly	101	28.1
Shortage of time	98	27.2
Getting better grades	95	26.4
I did not want to fail the semester	79	21.9
It helped to get degree	36	10.0

Motives for cheating mentioned in research sample can be categorized as external, internal or practical reasons. **External reasons** are those where individuals attribute their cheating to factors outside of themselves, such as the course structure, external pressures, or the actions of others. In the survey, the course perceived as uninteresting and its difficulty emerged as the biggest external drivers of cheating. This provides important insight into why students might resort to dishonest practices in these situations. Time constraints, often linked to poor time management or external responsibilities, also serve as an external pressure.

Internal reasons, on the other hand, occur when individuals feel personally responsible for their cheating. These reasons often stem from personal attributes like self-esteem, values, or emotions. In this research, low self-esteem is a key internal factor, where individuals may feel they are not capable of succeeding on their own, and cheating becomes a way to avoid failure. A high occurrence of the motive to get better grades could stem from internal pressures, such as personal ambition, competitiveness, or the desire to meet societal or personal expectations. The statement, "I did not want to fail the semester," reflects another internal reason, stemming from the fear of personal failure and the need to protect one's academic standing or future opportunities.

Practical and rational reasons for cheating are motives that stem from more logical or situational factors, where individuals may see cheating as a practical solution to the challenges they face. These reasons might not necessarily be "excuses" but practical responses to real problems. The statement, "Knew I would not get caught," reflects a more realistic calculation, where the individual assesses the situation and concludes that the risk of getting caught is low, making cheating seem like a reasonable option. "It helped to get a degree" can also be considered a rational reason, where cheating is seen as a means to an end—getting a degree. While this is viewed as unethical, it can be the result of pragmatic decisions made in a competitive or high-pressure academic environment.

In the sample, **external reasons** (e.g., course structure, environment) are more common, with motives such as course difficulty, uninteresting course, and unclear material representing the majority of responses. This suggests that many students view cheating as a reaction to external factors they cannot control, such as course design or teaching methods.

Internal reasons (e.g., self-esteem, personal ambition) also play a significant role, with up to half of the students acknowledging that personal pressures—such as fear of failure or the desire for better grades—contribute to their decisions. This suggests a significant emotional or psychological component to cheating, linked to self-worth and expectations.

Practical reasons (e.g., avoiding failure, using available technology) are less frequent but still notable. These motives reflect a pragmatic approach to cheating, where individuals believe that cheating is a low-risk, high-reward option in their particular context.

These findings suggest that universities and institutions may want to consider not only addressing personal or psychological factors (such as self-esteem and fear of failure) but also improving course structures and reducing environmental pressures in order to curb cheating.

4.7. “Excusable” and “Inexcusable” Motives for Cheating

The next item aimed to analyze students' perceptions of “excusable” and “inexcusable” motives for academic cheating. It is supposed that this distinction often emerges from students' own perceptions of their actions and the context in which they cheat. Excusable motives are those that students may feel justify their behavior, often linked to external pressures, emotional states, or situational factors. In this category, students may view cheating as a response to circumstances rather than a moral failing.

Student “Excusable” Motives Included - Time Pressure and Workload:

Students reported heavy workloads or insufficient time for studying often justify cheating as a necessary evil. For example, time constraints due to balancing work or multiple courses can lead students to feel that they have no choice but to cheat to meet academic expectations.

Perceived Unfairness or Inadequate Teaching:

Students who feel that the course material is too difficult, poorly taught, or unfairly assessed may view cheating as a way to level the playing field. Students frequently justified cheating when they perceived that the teacher's behavior or course structure was inadequate or when they felt that their efforts would not be properly recognized despite hard work.

Lack of Interest or Engagement in the Subject:

When students feel disconnected or uninterested in the subject matter, they may rationalize cheating as a way to get through the course without fully engaging with the content. This is related to intrinsic motivation; students who do not see value in the subject are less likely to engage honestly, viewing cheating as a pragmatic choice.

External Pressure for Good Grades:

Some students feel compelled to cheat due to the high stakes they face in achieving academic success, especially in competitive environments where grades are crucial for future opportunities like scholarships or job prospects. This type of pressure can make cheating seem like the only option to secure a positive outcome.

Student “Inexcusable” Motives for Cheating:

In contrast, inexcusable motives for cheating are those that are driven more by personal values or intentional disregard for academic integrity. These reasons are often seen as more morally indefensible and less likely to be viewed as justifiable by students themselves. Common inexcusable motives include:

Lack of Effort or Laziness:

Some students cheat because they do not want to put in the effort required to complete assignments or study for exams. These students may be motivated by a desire for the rewards (grades) without the work, and they may see cheating as a shortcut to success. Students who lack a strong work ethic or commitment to their studies are more likely to justify cheating purely for convenience.

Peer Pressure and Social Influence:

In some cases, students may cheat because of pressure from peers who normalize academic dishonesty. Peer pressure can lead students to believe that cheating is a common or expected behavior, even when they do not feel justified in doing so. Social learning theory suggests that students who are surrounded by others who cheat may internalize the behavior and come to view it as acceptable or even necessary.

Dishonest Intentions:

Students who engage in premeditated cheating—such as purchasing essays, plagiarizing, or using unauthorized materials—are less likely to see their behavior as excusable. This motive is more consciously driven by a desire to manipulate the academic system for personal gain without any real concern for the consequences. These actions are usually considered inexcusable because they reflect an intentional disregard for the values of honesty and fairness.

Cultural or Contextual Factors:

In some cases, students from certain cultural backgrounds or educational systems where cheating is normalized may not see their actions as wrong, even though they are considered inexcusable in the academic context. However, within the culture of academic integrity, these actions are typically considered unethical.

Table 7. “Excusable” motives for cheating

“Excusable” motives for cheating	n	%
Time pressure and workload	202	28.5
Perceived unfairness or inadequate teaching	197	27.8
Lack of interest in the subject	165	23.3
External pressure for good grades	144	20.3

Table 8. “Inexcusable” motives for cheating

“Inexcusable” motives for cheating	n	%
Lack of effort or laziness	280	34.3
Peer pressure and social influence	217	26.6
Dishonest intentions	203	24.9
Cultural or contextual factors	116	14.2

The excusable and inexcusable motives of the students for cheating are shown in Table 7 and Table 8. Excusable motives often involve external pressures (like time constraints or high expectations) or personal difficulties (like course difficulty or lack of engagement). Students who cheat for these reasons often feel that the context justifies their actions. Inexcusable motives tend to involve personal convenience, laziness, or a sense of entitlement. These are driven by a desire to achieve a goal without putting in the work, often disregarding ethical standards.

4.8. Methods to Detect Students Cheating

In the 9th and 10th items, students were asked about their knowledge of cheating detection they could face while cheating and their readiness to take risks. Item 9 was an open-ended question. Table 9 shows the detection methods that students are aware of.

Table 9. Potential detection methods as suggested by students

Detection method the students are aware of	n	%
Plagiarism detection SW, e.g., Turnitin, Copyscape)	278	77.2
AI-based detection tools	266	73.9
Proctored exams	114	31.7
Peer reports	66	18.3
Professors using software to detect inconsistencies in writing style	42	11.7

The highest percentage of students (77.2 %) are aware of plagiarism detection software. This suggests that students are familiar with software used to check for copied content in assignments and papers. 73.9 % of students are aware of AI-based detection tools. This indicates that a significant number of students recognize that artificial intelligence can be used to detect cheating, perhaps through analysis of patterns or anomalies in their work. 31.7 % of students mentioned proctored exams as a detection method. This is much lower than the first two methods, which might indicate that students are less familiar or concerned about in-person or online proctoring during exams as a form of cheating detection.

Only 18.3 % of students are aware that peers can report cheating. This suggests that students do not feel that peer reports are a primary method of detection, which could mean they do not consider peer surveillance or reporting a significant threat to their actions. The least recognized detection method is professors using software to analyze writing style inconsistencies, with just 11.7 % of students being aware of it. This might indicate that students either don't understand the depth of this method or do not consider it as a common way to detect cheating.

The results highlight a strong awareness of common detection tools like plagiarism detection software and AI-based tools. However, students seem less familiar with methods like proctored exams, peer reporting, and writing style analysis, which may influence how they perceive the risk of cheating. These findings could help shape future educational policies and awareness campaigns to ensure students understand the full range of academic integrity measures in place.

4.9. Readiness to Take Risks and Cheat

In the 9th and 10th items, students were asked about their knowledge of cheating detection they could face while cheating and their readiness to take risks. Item 9 was an open-ended question. Table 10 shows student readiness to cheat.

Table 10. Student readiness to cheat

Readiness to take risks	n	%
Yes	80	22.2
Maybe	220	61.1
No	60	16.7

A large portion of the respondents (61.1 %) are in the "maybe" category. This suggests that more than half of them might be open to taking risks but are uncertain or need more information or confidence before committing. 22.2 % of respondents say "yes" to taking risks, which indicates that while not a majority, a solid group of individuals are comfortable or willing to take risks. This group might be more adventurous or confident in their decision-making. A smaller percentage, 16.7 %, have answered "no" to taking risks. This group represents those who prefer to avoid risks or are less confident in uncertain situations. It is a good indication of risk-averse behavior in this student group.

4.10. Methods to Prevent Student Cheating

In the 9th and 10th items, students were asked about their knowledge of cheating detection they could face while cheating and their readiness to take risks. Item 9 was an open-ended question.

Table 11. Student cheating prevention

Pls suggest effective strategy for preventing cheating at universities	n	%
Strict monitoring and enforcement of rules	307	85.4
Awareness programs about the consequences of cheating	302	83.9
Use of advanced cheating detection tools	212	58.9
Providing students with adequate support and resources	317	88.0
Reducing the emphasis on high-stakes exams and assignments	301	83.6

As seen the results from Table 11, students suggested following steps to cheating reduction:

Providing students with adequate support and resources is the most popular strategy, suggesting that many students believe that proper resources and support are key to preventing cheating. Ensuring students have access to help, guidance, and learning resources can reduce the temptation to cheat. Strict monitoring and enforcement of rules (85.28%) is also highly favoured strategy as viewed by students, indicating that students recognize the importance of vigilance in preventing cheating. Stricter surveillance during exams and clearer consequences for violations may deter cheating.

Awareness programs about the consequences of cheating: Highlighting the negative effects of cheating on both academic integrity and long-term career prospects seems to resonate with a large portion of respondents, suggesting that education on consequences can help prevent cheating.

Reducing the emphasis on high-stakes exams and assignments: This result shows that students may feel high-pressure academic settings lead to increased cheating. Offering alternative assessment methods or lowering the stakes of individual exams could help in mitigating cheating.

Use of advanced cheating detection tools (58.89%): While this approach is the least favored, it is still seen as effective by a substantial number of respondents. However, this approach seems to be less preferred compared to proactive prevention strategies like support resources and awareness programs.

5. Discussion

The data received in the survey unsurprisingly confirm the high incidence of student cheating, with almost half of the respondents admitting to frequent cheating. These results align with other literature resources, mentioned by [9].

The prevailing types of student cheating are tied to digital resources, including AI. Cheating practices are evolving alongside advancements in technology, with methods like unethical AI assistance becoming more prevalent. As reported by Chan [14], investigating changes in understandings of academic misconduct has led to the emergence of a new term AI-giarism. This term refers to the unethical practice of using AI, particularly generative language models, to generate content that is plagiarized either from original human-authored work or directly from AI-generated content.

Academic cheating can be encouraged by the perception of how widespread dishonest behavior is among other students. Since a significant majority of the respondents perceive cheating as a frequent issue within the student community, this unethical behavior may, to some extent, lose its negative connotation.

When asked to suggest possible types of AI misuse in academic activities, students identified several options: essay/paper generation, paraphrasing/rewriting, answering exam questions, solving problem sets, suggesting research objectives, creating fake citations, completing written assignments, and providing homework solutions. This misuse of AI enables students to bypass learning, critical thinking or the development of their own knowledge and skills. On the other hand, it may paradoxically improve some students' verbal skills when they attempt to 'disguise' the AI-generated content and modify the text to reflect their 'personal style'.

The effort to study student motivation to cheat clearly distinguished the dominance of external motives as many students view cheating as a reaction to external factors they cannot control and cause by other members of the academic community (teachers, university management). The results align with general psychological theories, e.g., Social Learning Theory, Self-Determination Theory), or any other theory related to external influences on behavior, which suggest that individuals are more likely to engage in certain behaviors, like cheating, when they perceive external pressures or negative influences as driving forces behind their actions. Students also declare external factors to be excusable motives for cheating, while personal motives are viewed as inexcusable.

Recent research has focused on methods for detecting and preventing cheating in order to mitigate this negative phenomenon. Students in the research sample are aware of plagiarism detection software and AI detection software but are less familiar with other methods, such as using software to analyse inconsistencies in writing style. Nevertheless, most students are still willing to take risks, cheat, or consider the possibility of cheating.

As for the issue of preventing cheating, the results suggest that teacher involvement plays a crucial role. Teachers can enforce the rules, strictly monitor student achievements, or reduce the emphasis on high-stakes exams and assignments."

6. Conclusion

Developing more awareness programs and campaigns that clearly explain the academic, ethical, and future implications of cheating can discourage students from considering it as an option. Given the high preference for reducing the emphasis on high-stakes exams, universities could explore continuous assessment methods like project-based learning, peer reviews, or take-home assignments that encourage deeper learning and reduce the temptation to cheat.

Although advanced cheating detection tools are still valuable, their focus could be on spot-checking or addressing extreme cases rather than being a primary strategy. More proactive methods such as preventive education may be more widely accepted and effective.

In order to anticipate future, the intersection of student academic cheating and AI presents both challenges and opportunities for academic integrity. With the increasing reliance on digital technologies, AI tools will likely continue to evolve, making it easier for students to engage in dishonest practices. However, these advancements also offer powerful solutions for combating cheating. AI-driven plagiarism detection systems, real-time monitoring tools, and even AI-designed assessments that adapt to students' knowledge levels could make academic dishonesty more difficult to conceal. Additionally, AI can be leveraged to foster a culture of academic integrity, with personalized learning tools that encourage ethical decision-making and self-regulation.

In the future, the role of educators will shift towards not only addressing cheating but also integrating technology into the learning process in ways that promote fairness, accountability, and critical thinking. Universities could adopt more proactive, AI-enhanced methods for prevention, creating an environment where academic honesty becomes the standard, and students are encouraged to thrive based on their own abilities rather than seeking shortcuts. The key to a successful future will lie in a balanced approach, where AI helps both detect and prevent cheating while promoting an educational ecosystem based on trust and integrity.

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